

HEFTY HERBIVORE

SHANTUNGOSAURUS

The heavyweight *Shantungosaurus* is the largest of a group of plant-eating dinosaurs called the ornithomimids. *Shantungosaurus* had a broad beaklike mouth and strong jaws lined with hundreds of teeth that allowed this herbivore to turn even the toughest plant matter into the mushy pulp that fueled its bulky body. Herds of these massive plant guzzlers probably marched across the plains and swamps of Cretaceous China, making the most of the region's lush vegetation.

The jaws were packed with more than 1,500 chewing teeth.



STATS AND FACTS

Paleontologists have discovered fossils of more than 3,000 *Shantungosaurus* bones belonging to 55 individuals in a quarry in China. Undamaged by other scavenging animals, these fossils suggest that this herd may have been rapidly buried, possibly during a devastating flash flood.

WEIGHT



The oldest *Shantungosaurus* adults may have weighed up to 17.6 tons (16 tonnes), but only a few grew so large.

LENGTH OF THIGH BONE



The longest bone in a *Shantungosaurus* skeleton is the huge thigh bone, which measures up to 5½ ft (1.7 m).

Strength in numbers

Shantungosaurus probably moved in herds, which provided some safety from the deadly predators of the region. The sight of a herd of these giants marching together would have made hunters such as the terrifying *Zhuchengtyrannus* (a large tyrannosaurid) think twice about an attack.